

1 Revisionism, Order, and Rising Powers

Revisionism is a poorly understood concept. While analysts broadly agree that it refers to dissatisfaction, there is little further consensus. The term captures, in different formulations, anything from a willingness to pay more to change than defend the status quo to a commitment to bringing about a revolution in the international system. There is accordingly little agreement on questions about how to measure or explain dissatisfaction.

Yet revisionism is also one of the most significant concepts in international relations (IR). For classical realists, neoclassical realists, defensive realists, power transition theorists, and hegemonic stability theorists, dissatisfaction is one of the *key* variables in accounts of the causes of major war. This is particularly true for analyses of the international security consequences of the rise of new great powers. There is not *necessarily* any reason to expect rising powers to threaten international order. In fact, states experiencing or expecting relative increases in wealth or military power have incentives to integrate with status quo institutions; this prevents other powerful states from seeking to contain the riser and promises other concrete benefits. Leaders in historical rising states – in Wilhelmine Germany, Imperial Japan, and Weimar Germany – understood these incentives and tried to pursue foreign policies in line with them.

It is when rising powers grow dissatisfied with the status quo that they are dangerous. Dissatisfied states no longer see any value in integrating with status quo institutions and are willing to risk provocation by pursuing increasingly belligerent policies. This, according to many accounts, is what happened to Wilhelmine Germany, Imperial Japan, and Weimar Germany; and it is what some observers worry could happen to China in the coming decades.

For such a potentially consequential concept, we know little about what dissatisfaction is or where it comes from. In this chapter I take two steps that aim to help scholars and policymakers better understand the nature and sources of revisionism. First, I propose a disaggregated way of thinking about dissatisfaction with the status quo. States can be revisionist in two ways: they can be dissatisfied with the distribution of resources

in the system, and they can be dissatisfied with the rules, norms, and institutions that constitute and naturalize the distribution of resources and regulate interactions. These two types of dissatisfaction manifest themselves behaviorally as pressure for different kinds of policies, and they combine to form three ideal-typical revisionist policy orientations: *distributive revisionism*, which aims at achieving more of a material, economic, or social resource; *normative revisionism*, which rejects or aims to overthrow the normative and institutional foundation of the status quo; and *radical revisionism*, which combines policies aimed at satisfying distributive ambitions with those aimed at rejecting or overthrowing status quo norms, rules, and institutions.

My second objective in this chapter is to argue that policy combinations that look like radical revisionism are particularly puzzling and dangerous, especially when rising great powers pursue them. These states have incentives to pursue policies aimed at achieving distributive revisionist objectives; they simultaneously have incentives to do things that communicate a willingness to play by the rules and support status quo norms and institutions, since doing so reduces the costs and risks of expanding power, wealth, and influence. A radical revisionist policy mix – which adds normative revisionist policies aimed at *rejecting or overthrowing* status quo rules, norms, and institutions – is puzzling because it is needlessly provocative.

Radical revisionism is also dangerous. Distributive revisionist ambitions and demands for policies that reject or overthrow status quo rules, norms, and institutions interact in ways that push states toward the pursuit of increasingly unrestrained expansion. Leaders in states that positively value rule-breaking and norm violation are likely to calculate that the costs of behaving aggressively are lower than they would otherwise be, and elites who favor less restrained expansion will be less effectively constrained by the objections of more cautious leaders.

In short, my second objective in this chapter is to establish the need for a theoretical account of shifts from distributive toward radical revisionism in rising states: why do rising states committed to achieving limited distributive ambitions while avoiding provocation sometimes abandon the latter commitment and pursue policies that seem to lash out against status quo rules, norms, and institutions? The rest of this book develops and evaluates a theoretical explanation for these dangerous shifts.

What Is Revisionism?

Revisionism refers to an attitude of dissatisfaction with and corresponding desire to change the status quo. It is one pole along a continuum of

orientations toward the state of affairs in the international system. The opposite pole – a “status quo” orientation – refers to an attitude of satisfaction with and a desire to preserve the status quo. In the middle of the continuum is an “indifferent” orientation – this refers to an attitude of neither satisfaction nor dissatisfaction, and a corresponding lack of will to either defend or change the status quo.¹

This simple framework masks many outstanding questions. The most fundamental relates to the nature of the status quo and the corresponding aspirational change that revisionism denotes. There are two distinct ways of defining the status quo in the literature on revisionism.

The simplest and most common is to treat the status quo as a distribution of resources. This often refers to territory or power, but it may also mean the distribution of influence, wealth, markets, ideology, regime type, status, or some other valued good. Revisionism then denotes dissatisfaction with and a desire to change this distribution. This is how Wolfers understood the concept (which he called “self-extension”), and it is also the approach that more recent neoclassical and defensive realist scholarship has taken.²

The other way to conceptualize the status quo is as a social order composed of a power and status relationship between states and a set of norms and rules that help constitute and legitimate the order. On this view, revisionism refers to dissatisfaction with the foundation of the order, not with the distribution of resources in the system. In fact a state might seek distributive gains to be better positioned to *defend* the order. This is how Morgenthau (who used the term “imperialism”) and Kissinger (who used the term “revolutionary” state) understood revisionism – not as an effort to change the distribution of goods, but as dissatisfaction with a more fundamental set of social relationships and institutions.³

Instead of choosing between these two understandings of dissatisfaction, I propose a framework that accommodates both. The status quo, at any particular time and place, consists of *both* a distribution of resources (wealth, military capabilities, status, regime type, access to markets) *and* a set of norms, rules, and institutions that produces order by constituting actors with different statuses and bundles of rights, providing bases for legitimate action in international politics, and regulating behavior and interaction in ways that favor some actors over others.

¹ See Carr (1946), p. 53, for an early discussion.

² See Wolfers (1962), pp. 91–93. For recent usages consistent with this definition, see Kydd (1997), Schweller (1998), and Davidson (2006).

³ Morgenthau (1948), p. 57; Kissinger (1957), p. 2; (2014), p. 9. For recent consistent usages of the term, see Legro (2005), Chan (2004), and Buzan (2010).

The distributive element of the status quo is fairly straightforward and needs little elaboration. But the normative element requires greater attention. Norms, rules, and institutions play three roles that are central to understanding how they produce order and stratification in world politics, and why they might prompt dissatisfaction.

First, norms, rules, and institutions produce and sustain social hierarchies by generating intersubjective bases for social comparisons between actors, and by constituting actors with different statuses and bundles of rights.⁴ The most obvious and fundamental example is the constitution of the state itself. The institution of sovereignty provides a normative framework that makes possible the social category of the “state” and gives actors in this category certain rights and privileges – for instance, to manage affairs inside borders without interference.⁵ But international normative frameworks are also constitutive of different kinds of states with different statuses and bundles of rights. Towns, for instance, has shown that changing norms about the treatment of women are one basis on which states have been categorized as civilized and uncivilized over the last two centuries.⁶ Another example is the social category “great power,” which refers to an elite club (whose membership criteria have involved a socially constructed mix of material capabilities and civilizational characteristics) in which members have access to certain exclusive rights. Great powers today, for instance, are not just the most powerful states in the system – they are powerful states with rights to legitimately possess nuclear weapons, to privileged positions in global governance institutions, and to intervention abroad for the purpose of maintaining international peace and stability.⁷

Second, norms, rules, and institutions provide the basis for legitimate action in international politics. Leaders draw on normative frameworks (like the idea of the “balance of power,” the “responsibility to protect,” or the concept of universal human rights) and use formal and informal institutions (like the UN Security Council or the World Trade Organization) to legitimate foreign policies – like military interventions, occupations, economic sanctions, and the formalization of alliance

⁴ This understanding of the function of norms, institutions, and rules is similar to what Bially Mattern and Zarakol (2016, p. 641) call the “logic of productivity” – norms, institutions, and rules that generate hierarchy do so by producing “both the actors and the space of world politics in which they act.” On the constitutive properties of norms and institutions see Barnett and Duvall (2005) and Wendt (1998). For a thorough account of the ways in which norms constitute social hierarchies, see Towns (2010).

⁵ See Ruggie (1993). ⁶ Towns (2009, 2010, 2012).

⁷ On different conceptions of criteria for membership in the great power club, see Neumann (2014). On the rights of “great powers,” see Bull (1977), pp. 196–212; Simpson (2004), pp. 70–71; Suzuki (2008); and Heimann (2014).

commitments – for domestic and international audiences.⁸ These frameworks and institutions constrain the kinds of actions that can be taken by different kinds of actors – for instance, during the nineteenth century, European great powers invoked the responsibility to maintain stability and defend the balance of power in order to justify intervention in conflicts involving smaller European states. Later, Western actors invoked civilizational standards to justify intervention in and occupation of non-Western states. More recently, Western powers have invoked the illegitimacy of Iranian claims to a nuclear program – which is based on a normative framework that only grants such a right to certain kinds of states – in order to justify sanctions.⁹

Third, norms, rules, and institutions regulate interactions between states. They proscribe certain kinds of behavior and prescribe others.¹⁰ For instance, in the Sino-Centric East Asian order, there were elaborate rules that dictated how other states within that system had to behave during diplomatic interactions in order to receive the benefits of tributary trade with China.¹¹ Rules may also be less formal – like contemporary customary international law that regulates interstate interaction in the realms of war and commerce.

The normative element of the status quo is not completely independent of the distributive element. There are two important ways in which the two are related. First, norms, rules, and institutions partially constitute and naturalize the status quo distribution of resources.¹² For instance, the normative framework that denies legitimate possession of nuclear weapons to non-NPT nuclear states effectively ratifies the current distribution of nuclear weapons technology. Similarly, the nineteenth-century understanding that the “great powers” had a responsibility to maintain the European balance of power helped to discourage radical changes to the

⁸ For consistent perspectives, see constructivists like Reus-Smit (1999) and Bukovansky (2002); classical realists like Kissinger (2014); and the English School literature, including among others Bull (1977), Gong (1984), Wight (1977), Watson (1992), and Clark (2011).

⁹ Another way to understand this function of norms, institutions, and rules is as a manifestation of what Bially Mattern and Zarakol (2016, p. 641) call the “logic of positionality” – norms, institutions, and rules produce and reflect inequality by “constrain[ing] or influenc[ing] agent choices, behavior, and perceptions.”

¹⁰ On this function, see the realist Gilpin (1981) and the neoliberal literature on regimes, including among others Krasner (1982b), (1982a), and Keohane (1984). One might also understand this as a manifestation of what Bially Mattern and Zarakol (2016, p. 636) call the “logic of trade-offs” – norms and institutions “structure action, whether through social or interest-based incentives.”

¹¹ See Kang (2010) and Ringmar (2012).

¹² This was Carr’s (1946) point about international “morality” as a means of perpetuating the dominance of the privileged (Chapter 9, especially p. 155). For a related discussion, see Jackson (2011), p. 187.

distribution of capabilities.¹³ In short, status quo norms, rules, and institutions help produce an order that strengthens the privileged positions of those at the top.

Second, the character of status quo rules, norms, and institutions is partially determined by the identities, actions, and characteristics of the most powerful actors in the system. For instance, international order is often constructed in ways that reflect the preferences of the victors of major conflicts – as in the wake of the Napoleonic Wars, World War I, World War II, and the collapse of the Soviet Union.¹⁴ Powerful actors also influence the character of order-producing normative frameworks simply by virtue of being powerful. Shared understandings about the criteria for achieving “great power” status around the turn of the twentieth century, for instance, involved the construction of battleships and the acquisition of overseas territories in part because the state at the top of the global pecking order – Great Britain – had these in abundance.

The co-constitutive relationship between the normative and distributive elements of order suggests that often – but not always – the states benefiting the most from the status quo distribution of resources will also have an interest in defending status quo norms, rules, and institutions. And, whether it is true or not, other states often come to the same conclusion about the connection between the status quo distribution of resources and the rules, norms, and institutions that help legitimate it. Late risers throughout history have often inferred that the states most advantaged by the global distribution of power or wealth or status are also those whose interests are most closely identified with the defense and reproduction of status quo norms, rules, and institutions. For instance, many Japanese and German leaders understood the League of Nations and the post-World War I set of institutions as a framework that worked to the benefit of the states that already dominated international politics: the United States, Great Britain, and France. Similarly, some Chinese observers today understand the contemporary set of order-producing norms and institutions as a framework that primarily works to preserve American hegemony.¹⁵

Still, the reciprocal relationship between the normative and distributive elements of the status quo does *not* mean that dissatisfaction is an all-or-nothing proposition. The distribution of resources and the set of norms,

¹³ See Mitzen (2013) and Kissinger (2014), Chapter 2, on the functioning of the European Concert system for this purpose.

¹⁴ On this view of international order, see Gilpin (1981) and Ikenberry (2001).

¹⁵ See Chapters 4, 5, and 7. The recent rise of an unmistakable disdain for the “liberal international order” in the United States – which itself built and benefits more than any other state from the contemporary status quo – is an important reminder that rising power is not a *necessary* condition for the emergence of this sort of dissatisfaction. I return to this issue in the concluding chapter.

rules, and institutions that produce order are analytically distinct components of the status quo, and states can be satisfied with one and dissatisfied with the other. A dominant-but-declining state might be committed to defending status quo institutions but calculate that to do so, it must increase its share of the distribution of capabilities. Or a rising state might anticipate benefiting from status quo norms, rules, and institutions once it manages to achieve higher status. Conversely, a state might be dissatisfied with the normative basis of the international status quo but uninterested in changing the distribution of resources.

Distributive and Normative Dissatisfaction in Foreign Policy

Distributive and normative dissatisfaction are analytically distinct, and they manifest themselves behaviorally as commitments to different kinds of policies. Distributive dissatisfaction produces pressure to adjust the distribution of resources in the problematic area. This is straightforward when a state wants more wealth or territory – satisfaction comes through territorial or economic expansion. Ambitions for a more favorable distribution of other kinds of goods – like status or influence – push toward more complicated behavioral responses. These might, for instance, lead to demands for *reform* of international institutions to accommodate claims to a more important voice for the state in global governance – as in the case of Indian, Brazilian, and Japanese ambitions for permanent membership in the UN Security Council. They might also involve other forms of normative or institutional innovation or reform in order to improve a state's position in the system.¹⁶ But this is all ultimately motivated by *distributive* dissatisfaction – a desire for higher status or more influence. It should not be confused with evidence of a fundamental opposition to the norms, rules, and institutions that produce the order itself. In fact, this sort of status or influence-seeking actually signals, at a deeper level, acceptance of the norms and institutions that produce the status quo – states with these sorts of ambitions are happy to play by the rules so long as status quo rules and institutions can be adjusted to accommodate claims to more status or influence.

Efforts at institutional reform depend upon the acceptance of a deeper framework by which states can amend the status quo norms, rules, and institutions – a framework still rooted in the status quo order and the

¹⁶ See, for instance, the discussion of Japan's attempt to renegotiate the role of "whiteness" as a marker of great power status in Chapter 4; Towns' (2010, 2012) account of the emergence of gender-based legislative quotas among states hoping to improve their standing; and Larson and Shevchenko's (2003, 2010, 2014) conception of social creativity.

support of its defenders. In the realm of domestic politics, the process by which constitutions provide for their own future amendment is an obvious example, but amendment frameworks exist in international politics as well. Historically, these have included the nineteenth-century European concert system, ad hoc conferences among great powers and other states (like the Congress of Berlin, the Hague Conferences, and the interwar disarmament conferences in Geneva, Washington, and London), and formal institutions – most prominently the UN General Assembly – that provide states with legitimate forums through which to change international normative and legal frameworks. Some institutions – like the UN Security Council and the WTO – even have explicit procedures for effecting institutional changes. The key point is that institutional and normative reforms pursued through these legitimate channels do not represent challenges to the foundation of the status quo order – rather, they strengthen the status quo order by demonstrating that its norms, institutions, and rules are flexible and durable enough to accommodate the changing demands of states.¹⁷

Normative dissatisfaction runs deeper and pushes not toward pressure for marginal reforms to rules or institutions but rather for policies that deny, challenge the legitimacy of, or aim at overthrowing the norms, rules, and institutions that constitute the status quo order. It manifests itself behaviorally in the form of policies of delegitimation and revolution. States that are deeply dissatisfied with the normative and institutional framework that constitutes the status quo order will not pursue changes within the order (since doing so only strengthens its basis), but rather behave in ways that weaken or destroy the order by protesting, denying its legitimacy, or seeking to overthrow it.¹⁸

More concretely, deep normative dissatisfaction can manifest itself in a range of provocative behaviors. These include violent attempts to destroy and replace the international order – much like revolutions are violent attempts to overthrow domestic orders. But there are also less extreme manifestations of normative dissatisfaction. Normatively dissatisfied states positively value breaking rules and violating norms because doing so signals protest and weakens the normative foundation of the status quo. Along these lines, states express normative dissatisfaction by refusing to participate in or withdrawing from status quo institutions. Normative dissatisfaction might also push against cooperating with states identified as defenders of the status quo order. Doing so, especially in

¹⁷ The distinction here is similar to the one Buzan (1991), pp. 237–246; (2010), pp. 17–18, draws between revolutionary revisionists and reformist revisionists.

¹⁸ This is consistent with Chan's (2004) definition (p. 216), as well as his argument that revisionism can be identified by observing relative levels of membership in IGO's.

Table 1.1 *Ideal-Typical Policy Combinations*

	Accept Status Quo Norms, Rules, and Institutions	Reject Status Quo Norms, Rules, and Institutions
Defend (or Decline to Challenge) Distribution of Resources	Satisfied	Normative Revisionist
Examples	<i>(Pre-World War I Great Britain)</i>	<i>(Tokugawa Japan; early Soviet Union)</i>
Challenge Distribution of Resources	Distributive Revisionist	Radical Revisionist
Examples	<i>(Prussia/Germany under Bismarck; post-Meiji Japan; Germany under Stresemann)</i>	<i>(Revolutionary France; pre- World War I Germany; post- 1933 Japan; Nazi Germany)</i>

ways that seem intended to participate in the management or governance of the status quo order, at least tacitly signals that the status quo is valuable and the privileged position of its defenders is valid. This message is inconsistent with the demand for delegitimation that is associated with normative dissatisfaction.

Revisionist Foreign Policy Combinations

The two dimensions of dissatisfaction combine to form four ideal-typical orientations toward the status quo (depicted in Table 1.1). These can be understood more concretely as policy combinations. States in the real world will never fit cleanly into any ideal-typical category – ideal types exist only in the form of theories and ideas. But states do pursue policy combinations that resemble (more or less closely) one orientation or another; and it is possible to identify *shifts* from a mix of policies that resembles one orientation toward a mix that more closely resembles another. In other words, this framework is particularly useful for characterizing *changes* in the orientation of a state's foreign policy.

The first orientation is satisfaction with both the distribution of resources in a system and the status quo norms, rules, and institutions. This combination is not revisionist at all; it instead consists of a mix of policies committed to defending the distribution of power and other resources, and upholding the legitimacy of the status quo's normative framework. This approximates Great Britain's orientation toward the status quo during the decades before World War I.

There are three revisionist policy combinations. The first – distributive revisionism – refers to the simultaneous pursuit of a change in the distribution of some resource and a commitment to defending (or at least not challenging) status quo norms, rules, and institutions. This is a common mix. States are frequently dissatisfied with how much of some resource they have, but this does not have to be accompanied by fundamental opposition to the rules, norms, and institutions of the order. In fact, states pursuing distributive revisions have incentives to follow a *logic of institutional restraint* – to avoid provoking others by signaling a broader commitment to keeping competition constrained within the bounds of the order's norms, rules, and institutions.¹⁹ Otto von Bismarck understood this logic and worked to defuse potential opposition from other great powers during the Wars of German Unification by legitimating expansion as a *defense* of the normative and institutional foundation of the nineteenth-century European status quo.²⁰ Similarly, Japanese Foreign Minister Kijūrō Shidehara and Weimar Foreign Minister Gustav Stresemann sought to expand the power, wealth, status, and influence of their respective states, but simultaneously worked to signal acceptance of the normative and institutional frameworks of the post-World War I order as a way of making their distributive revisionist efforts less costly and risky.

The second revisionist orientation – normative revisionism – combines policies that reject status quo norms, rules, and institutions with disinterest in changing the distribution of resources in the system. This is perhaps less common than distributive revisionist orientations, but there are some examples of states pursuing these kinds of policy combinations. Japan under the Tokugawa is one. In the wake of Toyotomi Hideyoshi's failed attempt to invade and conquer Korea and China, it was clear to the Tokugawa that efforts to change the distribution of power, territory, and influence in early modern East Asia were futile and much less important than consolidating domestic authority. Yet the Tokugawa simultaneously refused to participate in the norms and institutions that constituted the Sino-Centric order. Beginning in the early seventeenth century, Japan symbolically withdrew from that order by refusing to engage in tributary trade, participate in the institution of investiture, and use diplomatic language and protocols that signaled subservience to China.²¹ Early Soviet foreign policy is another example of this sort of combination. In the immediate aftermath of the Russian Revolution, the Soviet Union eschewed distributive gains while seeking to

¹⁹ For similar arguments about the logic of signaling restraint through institutions, see Voeten (2005) and Ikenberry (2001).

²⁰ Goddard (2009), pp. 126–139. ²¹ See Toby (1984), pp. 29–94.

overthrow what its leaders saw as a global order produced by the norms, rules, and institutions of global capitalism.²² Some strains of American isolationist thought have also expressed a preference for policy combinations that reject distributive gains but at the same time withdraw from and delegitimize the status quo order.²³

The third revisionist orientation – radical revisionism – refers to simultaneous dissatisfaction along both distributive and normative dimensions. It thus results in combinations of policies that aim at making distributive gains and policies that aim at protesting, delegitimizing, or overthrowing the norms, rules, and institutions at the core of the status quo order. This combination – as I detail in the next section – is deeply provocative and thus puzzling, and also deeply destabilizing. Some of the most rabidly belligerent states in modern history have pursued combinations of policies that look like radical revisionism. These include Revolutionary France, which combined a deeply destabilizing challenge to the monarchical status quo with a concerted effort to conquer much of Europe; Wilhelmine Germany, which had similarly aggressive distributive ambitions that coexisted alongside an increasing discomfort with the British-managed “balance of power” European order during the years just before World War I; Imperial Japan, which after 1933 simultaneously pursued policies aimed at expanding in mainland Asia and protesting Western rules and institutions; and late Weimar and Nazi Germany, which by the early 1930s was pursuing increases in military power and territory while simultaneously protesting and delegitimizing the norms and institutions of the interwar European order.²⁴

The latter three cases suggest that radical revisionist policy combinations are particularly likely to arise in and particularly dangerous when pursued by rising states. But it is important to keep in mind that rising great powers are not the only actors who occasionally pursue these sorts of policy combinations. Although dominant states often have incentives to defend

²² Jacobson (1994), Chapters 1 and 2.

²³ See Nau (2013), pp. 42–44, for an overview of American isolationism, and Tucker and Hendrickson (1990), pp. 149–150, on Jefferson’s simultaneously revolutionary and isolationist strategic thought.

²⁴ One question that may arise at this point involves challenges for system leadership: should these be classified as distributive (since they involve dissatisfaction over the distribution of power, influence, or status) or should they be classified as radical (since they involve overturning the system’s hierarchy)? In a scenario in which a leading and challenging state agreed on what the social and institutional foundations of order in world politics should look like, then we might code the challenger’s revisionism as distributive. But since leadership challenges rarely occur in the absence of conflict over the order’s normative and institutional foundation (see Gilpin 1981 and the description of Gilpin’s account of change below for more on why this is so), in practice the challenger’s revisionism will almost always look more radical than distributive.

both the distribution of resources and status quo norms, rules, and institutions, they sometimes behave otherwise. American foreign policy under the George W. Bush administration might be understood as a very mild radical revisionist mix.²⁵ Many neoconservatives expressed preferences for a combination of policies that aimed simultaneously at expanding American power and influence and delegitimizing the norms and institutions (like the United Nations and the International Criminal Court) that previous American policy had built and defended. And though it is too early to draw firm conclusions about how this will influence American foreign policy, Donald Trump has articulated a worldview that expresses strong dissatisfaction with the normative foundation of the liberal international order and vague ambitions to shift the distribution of resources (including status, wealth, and military power) toward the United States.²⁶

Much weaker actors can also pursue radical revisionist policy combinations. The most prominent recent example might be the foreign policy of the “Islamic State” (IS). IS simultaneously seeks to change the distribution of territory and wealth in the Middle East and to overthrow not just the Western normative and institutional order, but also the Westphalian foundation of the state system itself.²⁷

Radical Revisionist Shifts in the Foreign Policies of Rising Great Powers

This book does not propose a universal theory of revisionism. States likely pursue different kinds of revisionist policy combinations for many reasons, and trying to capture these in a single theoretical framework would be futile. I do not even attempt to develop a general theory of radical revisionism. Rather, my focus in this book is limited to developing an explanation for *shifts* in the direction of radical revisionist policy combinations among one particular class of actors: rising great powers. Radical revisionism in states whose position in the international system seems to be improving deserves special attention for two reasons, on which I elaborate below. First, because of the incentives that rising states have to behave patiently and cautiously as they grow and expand, that they would adopt such deeply provocative policy combinations is puzzling. Second, shifts in the direction of radical revisionist combinations in the foreign policies of rising great powers are especially dangerous and destabilizing.

²⁵ See Chan (2004), p. 234, on this point.

²⁶ For an exhaustive overview of Trump’s worldview, see Laderman and Simms (2017).

²⁷ For an account of the Islamic State’s foreign policy ambitions, see Graeme Wood (2015).

*The Puzzle of Shifts Toward Radical Revisionist Policy
Combinations in Rising States*

Rising great powers present challenges and potential threats to states that benefit from the status quo order. As the debate about the rise of China among American academics and policymakers demonstrates, power shifts create uncertainty because of ambiguity about the intentions of the riser and the long-term consequences of its rise. Observers disagree about what China wants, whether it can rise peacefully, and whether it can integrate successfully with status quo norms and institutions. Different answers to these questions have different implications for American policy toward China. Those who think China is likely to pose a deep challenge to the status quo advocate robust military (and even economic) containment, while those who think China can integrate with the status quo order advocate engagement.

Chinese leaders are – as leaders in other rising states have been – aware of the international debate about their intentions and – as leaders in other rising states have as well – understand the corresponding incentives they have to avoid behaving provocatively. In order to weaken the advocates of containment and strengthen the advocates of engagement within potential balancers, rising states have incentives to avoid acting in ways that seem to confirm the fears of those who worry that they may launch revolutionary challenges against the status quo.²⁸

This does not mean that rising states should never be expected to pursue any kind of revisionist policy. They may require economic expansion in order to continue growing; they may redefine their security requirements as they grow in ways that push toward territorial expansion; and their leaders and populations may demand increases in status and influence concomitant with their new strength. Leaders might also calculate that increasing capabilities provide new opportunities to pursue a broader range of objectives than they could previously.

But when they do pursue distributive revisions to the status quo, rising states have strong incentives to do so without simultaneously signaling that they are interested in challenging the normative and institutional foundation of the order. Other states are more likely to accept distributive changes when the state pursuing them seems willing to integrate, play by the rules, and cooperate in the governance of the system. States that are satisfied with the norms, rules, and institutions that constitute the status

²⁸ This is one reason why Chinese leaders since Deng Xiaoping have stressed restraint in foreign policy (under labels like “keeping a low profile,” “peaceful rise,” and “peaceful development”). See Guo (2006), Chapter 1; Deng (2008), p. 41; and Zheng (2011), Chapter 6.

quo order are more likely to be behaviorally constrained by them. They are also unlikely to use any new increases in wealth, power, or influence to try to delegitimize or overthrow the normative and institutional foundation upon which the privileged position of other powerful states is partially based. Conversely, states that are dissatisfied with status quo norms, rules, and institutions positively value violating them and opposing their defenders. They are thus less behaviorally constrained and more likely to be seen as deeply destabilizing threats as they grow more powerful.²⁹

In short, leaders in rising states have compelling reasons to behave in ways that reassure more powerful states that they accept the normative and institutional foundation of the status quo order – even as they seek to expand their power and influence.³⁰ This is precisely why Bismarck invoked the sanctity of a treaty brokered by the British as justification for invading Schleswig-Holstein in 1864.³¹ It is also why Bethmann Hollweg tried to mend German relations with Great Britain before World War I, and why Japanese and German moderates objected to violating the rules of the interwar order and to withdrawing from the League of Nations.

History shows, though, that rising states sometimes behave in ways contrary to these incentives. Elites and the public in Wilhelmine Germany developed and expressed a deep antipathy to the British-dominated order that contributed to Germany's reckless foreign policy in the months before the July Crisis; Imperial Japan and Weimar/Nazi Germany took steps that signaled an unwillingness to integrate with the status quo order – steps that leaders in both states understood might lead to unnecessary isolation and disaster. Given the incentives that rising states have to avoid unnecessary provocation, their occasional unwillingness or inability to avoid policies that lash out in protest against the status quo order defies easy explanation.

The Dangers of Radical Revisionist Policy Combinations

Radical revisionist policy combinations are not just interesting because they are puzzling; they are also particularly dangerous in ways that distributive and normative revisionist policies on their own are not.

²⁹ Put another way, states that seem to reject the status quo order may pose what Weisiger (2013), pp. 25–33, calls “dispositional” commitment problems for other states.

³⁰ The literature on reassurance (Osgood 1962; Etzioni 1962; Stein 1991) suggests that it is easiest to convince others of one's benign intentions if one is willing to use institutions of global governance and respect status quo norms and rules related to international competition. See especially Stein (1991), pp. 432–433.

³¹ Goddard (2009), pp. 133–134.

Support for status quo norms, rules, and institutions tends to limit the ambitions of a distributive revisionist. Since the state values the rules and has an interest in strengthening or at least not undermining them, its behavior should be sensitive to the costs of rule-breaking. And since global governance institutions often constitute mechanisms for limiting the extent to which conflicting interests and ambitions threaten other actors and the status quo order itself, a commitment to respecting these kinds of institutions naturally channels dissatisfaction with the distribution of resources in a system toward policies that seek consensual adjustments. This was the intended (and, for a time, actual) function of the Concert of Europe; it was also the intended function of both the League of Nations and the United Nations Security Council. Each of these institutions was meant to help states limit the consequences of inevitable conflicts of interest (which often stem from distributive dissatisfaction). An interest in strengthening these institutions would thus present an important justification for limiting aggressive unilateral action that might simultaneously undermine the institution and threaten other great powers.

Conversely, a *demand* for delegitimation, protest, or overthrow of the status quo order removes this justification for limiting the pursuit of distributive revisions and thus reduces constraints on expansion. Imagine an idealized domestic debate over foreign policy within a rising state. There are two kinds of leaders – moderates, who prefer policies of pragmatic caution; and hardliners, who prefer more aggressive expansionist policies. All participants have to make public arguments to try to win support from other elites and the public. As the case studies in Chapters 3, 4, and 5 show, moderate leaders quite often invoke the costs of international rule-breaking and norm violation as an important argument against hardline policies. But when domestic audiences *positively value* policies that protest the legitimacy of status quo norms, rules, and institutions, that particular moderate objection is not politically sustainable. This empowers the advocates of expansion, whose preferred policies have the benefit of seeming to signal a rejection of the legitimacy of the status quo order. So while normative satisfaction tends to function as an obstacle for proponents of expansion, normative dissatisfaction makes less restrained expansion politically attractive.

This process is implicated in the increasingly aggressive behavior of Wilhelmine Germany, Imperial Japan, and Weimar/Nazi Germany as they grew more powerful. In each case, deep dissatisfaction with the status quo order undermined moderate leaders as they attempted to pursue pragmatic, cautious policies. In Wilhelmine Germany, this hampered Bethmann Hollweg's effort to facilitate a rapprochement with Great Britain and may have contributed to Germany's unwillingness to

back down in the last days of July 1914. In Imperial Japan, it forced moderates to accede to hardliner demands for withdrawal from the League of Nations, which in turn empowered advocates of expansion in mainland Asia and unrestrained naval building. In Weimar Germany, increasing anger at the norms, rules, and institutions of the interwar order aided the rise of the NSDAP (the Nazis) and incentivized leaders (even before Hitler) to pursue deeper revisions to the Versailles settlement than pragmatists like Gustav Stresemann would ever have contemplated.

Of course, normative dissatisfaction on its own does not *necessarily* make states particularly dangerous. Depending on its depth and the apparent feasibility of launching a military challenge, it *may* push only toward policies that delegitimize and protest status quo rules, norms, and institutions, and states can sometimes satisfy these drives without acting violently or aggressively. The case of Tokugawa Japan illustrates how this is possible. Beginning in the early seventeenth century, Japan simply stopped participating in the institutions that constituted the Sino-Centric East Asian order. But this did not lead to military conflict – indeed Tokugawa leaders were well aware of how foolish this would be in the wake of Hideyoshi's failed campaign in Korea. Instead, the result was that Japan founded a parallel international order and refused to interact with other Sinic states in particular ways.

But in combination with significant distributive revisionist ambitions, normative dissatisfaction can help produce deeply aggressive postures that are dangerous and destabilizing for the rising state, its neighbors, and the status quo order. This book is devoted to understanding the origins of this explosive mix of revisionist policies.

Existing Explanations for Radical Revisionism

Why do rising states, which have incentives to pursue limited distributive change while expressing support for status quo rules, norms, and institutions, sometimes do things that run counter to this incentive structure? Why do they sometimes pursue policies that protest, delegitimize, or seek to overthrow the status quo order? Why do they sometimes fail to take steps that would make the pursuit of distributive change cheaper and less risky by signaling that they accept the broader legitimacy of the order and are willing to play by its rules? IR theorists have proposed three broad answers to these questions. Realist explanations invoke the costs and benefits of working within versus radically remaking the order; constructivist explanations invoke the normative or ideological distance between the rising state's vision of order and the status quo; and domestic explanations invoke a process in which the way elites with distributive

revisionist preferences sell their policies to the public potentially pushes them to act in much more provocative ways. While none of these accounts tells a completely satisfying story, they offer important insights that I draw on as I develop my own theoretical framework in Chapter 2.

Realism and the Costs and Benefits of Revolutionary Change The most important realist theoretical account of the origins of radical revisionist ambitions in rising great powers is Gilpin's. The conceptual framework at the core of *War and Change in World Politics* is similar in important ways to the one developed above. Gilpin's international systems are defined by distributions of resources and of prestige, and also by sets of rules and institutions that both help produce and are produced by the distribution of resources and prestige. The system's rules and institutions are set up in ways that benefit the actors at the top of the hierarchy of prestige, and these actors work to defend the status quo.

Rising states unsettle the status quo because their increasing power makes it profitable for them to demand and seek change. Gilpin envisions two distinct kinds of changes that rising powers may pursue. The most common is "incremental change." Gilpin describes this as a process of "continuous incremental adjustments within the framework of the existing system."³² It involves limited shifts in the distribution of territory, wealth, influence, and prestige, and in alliances. This kind of change is best described as evolutionary, and it relieves the "pressure" on the system produced by uneven rates of growth.³³ Incremental change, in other words, is very closely related to the notion of distributive revisionism – rising states quite often seek changes in the system's distribution of resources but in ways that do not threaten the deeper foundation of the order.

The other kind of change is much less common and much more consequential. Gilpin calls this "revolutionary" change. States sometimes "believe that their interests can be served only by more sweeping and more profound changes in the international system."³⁴ When this is the case what is at "issue is the nature and governance of the system itself and/or, more rarely, the character of the international actors themselves."³⁵ Crises brought on by this sort of "constitutional" conflict "raise the basic issue of whose security, economic, and ideological interests will be most benefited by the functioning of the international system."³⁶ Gilpin's "revolutionary" change is closely related to the notion of radical

³² Gilpin (1981), p. 45. ³³ Ibid., pp. 45–46. ³⁴ Ibid., p. 46. ³⁵ Ibid., p. 46.

³⁶ Ibid., p. 46.

revisionism – states with gripes about the distribution of resources also sometimes grow dissatisfied with the deep foundation of the order itself.

The story that Gilpin tells in *War and Change* is ultimately a story about why demands for incremental change sometimes morph into much more destabilizing demands for revolutionary change. His account, in brief, is that insurmountable obstacles to incremental change lead the rising state to grow dissatisfied with the order itself. While incremental changes are cheaper and less risky, the rising state will become willing to challenge the status quo more deeply if its objectives “cannot be realized in the framework of the existing system.”³⁷ For Gilpin, this is typically the case because dominant but declining states are unwilling to make concessions until it is too late to appease the riser. A “disequilibrium” develops, produced by the tendency of the riser to grow faster than the system can adjust to its rise. This situation pushes toward hegemonic war as the increasingly radical demands of the riser convince the declining hegemon that the rising state cannot be appeased in a way consistent with the hegemon’s vital interests, and that fighting now is better than fighting later. The outcome of the hegemonic war then leads to the constitution of a new system built to satisfy the interests of the victor, and the cycle begins again.³⁸

Gilpin’s insight about the relationship between obstructed incremental demands and the emergence of revolutionary demands is critically important and is at the core of the theoretical explanation I develop in Chapter 2. But the claim as it is presented in *War and Change* is problematic because it cannot explain why the rising state would risk disaster to transform the order. For one thing, Gilpin’s conception of what rising great powers want is spare. Like many other realist accounts, *War and Change* focuses on demands for economic and security resources. Rising states seek increases in wealth and territory because the economic and security benefits of doing so begin to outweigh the costs.³⁹ But economic and security calculations are often not enough to explain demands for revolutionary change. As Ikenberry and others have persuasively argued, rising states often profit from free-riding on the institutional and normative frameworks of systems built and maintained by other states.⁴⁰ China, for instance, benefits from American-backed international rules and institutions that contribute to a global commitment to open markets, and from the American provision of public goods that keep shipping routes open, ensure the availability of resources like oil, and suppress defense spending in other East Asian states. It is far from clear why a

³⁷ Ibid., p. 46. ³⁸ Ibid., Chapter 5. ³⁹ Ibid., pp. 81–82, 95.

⁴⁰ See Ikenberry (2014), pp. 102–104; (2011), pp. 343–344; Schweller and Pu (2014).

Chinese leadership motivated by economic and security concerns would care to challenge American hegemony and the institutions, norms, and rules it maintains. Similarly, many moderate leaders in the rising great powers of the early twentieth century understood that their economic and security interests were better served by working within the existing order than by challenging it. This implies that we may need to go beyond wealth and security-seeking to explain demands for revolutionary change by rising great powers.

Moreover, Gilpin's conception of states as basically rational actors does not sit well with the claim that they respond to obstructions by escalating their demands.⁴¹ According to Gilpin, the expanding objectives of states as they rise are the result of an evolving cost/benefit calculation. States begin demanding change when the benefits exceed the costs, and they continue to do so until the costs exceed the benefits. These same "hyper-rational" cost/benefit calculators are supposed to respond to obstructed incremental demands by making more radical demands. But it is not obvious why a rational actor would do this. Demands for revolutionary change, in Gilpin's framework, raise the probability of hegemonic war. And hegemonic wars are costly, messy, and unpredictable affairs, which is why Gilpin appeals to non-rational mechanisms – emotions like anxiety, and the tendency for events to "escape from human control" – to explain their initiation.⁴²

This creates significant ambiguity within Gilpin's account: why would a rational actor respond to obstructed incremental demands by making revolutionary demands that convince other states that it cannot be appeased and thereby raise the probability of apocalyptic conflict?⁴³ Moderate leaders in early twentieth-century Germany and Japan raised similar objections to what they thought were unnecessarily provocative moves that seemed to promise only isolation and eventual disaster. What this implies is that we need to go beyond mechanisms that appeal to rational cost/benefit calculations to understand why obstructed incremental demands sometimes lead states to make demands for revolutionary change.

Normative Distance and International Order Constructivist explanations for radical revisionist policy combinations appeal to the ideological or normative "distance" between the rising power and the status quo order. The clearest exposition of this approach is Kupchan's

⁴¹ See Kirshner (2014), pp. 142–151, on this critique.

⁴² Gilpin (1981), p. 202; see also Kirshner (2014), pp. 156–157.

⁴³ Perhaps this behavior is a form of brinkmanship, though this interpretation does not appear in Gilpin's account.

recent work on the social foundations of hegemony.⁴⁴ Kupchan's argument is straightforward. States have varying ways of ordering political, social, and economic relations within their own borders. Some value democratic institutions and market economies; others practice authoritarian rule and have command economies; states also vary in the way their domestic social institutions express cultural values, like religion. As states become more powerful, they seek to export these normative "packages" as ways of ordering international politics within their spheres of influence. They do this both because leaders in the "metropole" believe their normative packages are the most appropriate, and because these packages are the visions of order with which elites are most familiar and comfortable.⁴⁵

This means that hegemonic transitions "entail competition over norms and rules as well as position and status."⁴⁶ The more different the dominant normative "package" is from the riser's preferred package, the more likely the rising state will seek deep changes in status quo rules, norms, and institutions. When a rising state and a dominant state have similar visions of domestic order, their visions of international order will also coincide and the transition should not destabilize the normative foundation of the status quo. Kupchan suggests, along these lines, that the peacefulness and normative continuity of the Anglo-American power transition may be attributable to the Anglo-American consensus about the "Anglo-Saxon" vision of order.⁴⁷ Conversely, incompatible visions of order lead the rising state to reject status quo norms, rules, and institutions and turn the transition into an ideological conflict – by way of example Kupchan cites the competition between fascism, communism, and liberal democracy between the beginning of World War II and the end of the Cold War.⁴⁸

The study of hegemonic transitions has been dominated by scholars interested in material sources of conflict, and Kupchan's argument is an invaluable corrective. But the focus on the normative distance between the rising state and the status quo order as a driver of conflict obscures two critical parts of the story. The first is that competing visions of order are contested domestically, not just internationally. Fascism may have contributed to the radically revisionist orientations of Imperial Japan and Nazi Germany prior to and during World War II. But during the 1920s and early 1930s, proponents of the fascist vision of order existed in Germany and Japan alongside proponents of alternative visions that were more compatible with the norms, rules, and institutions of the interwar status quo.

⁴⁴ See Kupchan (2012; 2014a; 2014b). See also Haas (2005) and Owen (2010).

⁴⁵ Kupchan (2014b), pp. 25–26; (2014a), pp. 225–226. ⁴⁶ Kupchan (2014b, p. 26).

⁴⁷ Ibid., p. 21. ⁴⁸ Ibid., p. 26.

There was nothing inevitable about the eventual dominance of the normatively distant fascist vision. Visions of domestic order – along with their implications for the way a state approaches the question of international order – are subject to domestic political contestation. This means that invoking ideological distance to explain why a rising state might challenge status quo norms, rules, and institutions entails not just identifying the sources of normative difference, but also accounting for the domestic victory of one vision of order over the alternatives.

The second complication follows directly from the first. Domestic visions of order have implications for foreign policy and international politics. But international politics also influence domestic contests over competing visions of order. Proponents of competing normative “packages” frequently base their foreign policy prescriptions on predictions about the behavior of other states and the feasibility and profitability of integrating with the status quo order. This means that foreign behavior can provide resources that actors in other states might be able to deploy to gain political advantages. The end of the Cold War provides a particularly striking example of this process. Gorbachev and his allies were committed to implementing a more open domestic political and economic order that would be ideologically closer to (and thus more compatible with) the Western international order. They were opposed, though, by Soviet hardliners who rejected both domestic reforms and rapprochement with the West. In order to prevail over the hardliners, Gorbachev needed to be able to demonstrate the feasibility and profitability of rapprochement, which meant that the Reagan administration’s increasingly friendly treatment of the Soviet regime during its second term was critical both to the reform of the Soviet Union’s domestic order and to the end of the Cold War.⁴⁹ Conversely, I show in Chapter 5 that proponents of the normatively distant fascist vision of order in Weimar Germany drew upon what they interpreted as unfair treatment by Western great powers to discredit moderate proponents of a more liberal vision.

This “second-image reversed” element implies that the relationship between normative distance and deep challenges to the status quo order is complicated by a reciprocal relationship between international politics and domestic visions of order. Normative distance may matter, but if it is partially (at least in some cases) caused by other factors, then there is more to the story. The theoretical account that I develop in Chapter 2 is sensitive to this complexity and proposes one particularly important process through which the behavior of foreign actors influences domestic contests over how to approach the status quo international order.

⁴⁹ See Evangelista (1993, p. 176); Brands (2014), pp. 126–139.

Entrapment and the Domestic Politics of Radical Revisionism The most relevant domestic theoretical frameworks are not pitched as explanations for policies that express deep dissatisfaction with the status quo order, but rather as explanations for “over-expansion,” understood as unnecessary, self-defeating aggressive behavior.⁵⁰ Still, they are worth considering because radical revisionist policy combinations are a form of sub-optimally aggressive behavior.

Domestic accounts of over expansion vary tremendously in their conceptions of the sources of individual and small-group interests in aggressive foreign policies.⁵¹ What they share is a commitment to a common mechanism that explains how aggressive elite interests produce self-defeating grand strategy: political and rhetorical entrapment. Snyder and Kupchan, for instance, both argue that elites with expansionist interests propagate “myths” or “images” about the relationship between security and expansion that help them convince the public to support aggressive foreign policies. But later, when it becomes clear to them that their policies are self-defeating and need to be adjusted, they find themselves trapped by the dominance of the very same myths and images they helped produce.⁵² Christensen similarly invokes entrapment to explain why a leader who must oversell an expensive policy to a hesitant public by exaggerating moral or ideological threats might then be forced to pursue a sub-optimally aggressive grand strategy “in order to maintain the appearance of consistency between rhetoric and practice.”⁵³

It is not difficult to see how the mechanism of entrapment could help explain why rising powers might pursue radical revisionist policy combinations. In order to sell expansionist policies to the public, elites might try to propagate ideas about the undesirability of supporting status quo norms, rules, and institutions. If they succeed, they may be forced to actually take steps consistent with this rhetoric, like withdrawing from an international institution. They could also be prevented from taking steps – like cooperating with states committed to defending the status quo – that might make sense for strategic reasons but be inconsistent with the notion that the international order is illegitimate.

The domestic entrapment story is compelling and powerful, and a closely related set of mechanisms plays an important role in the theoretical

⁵⁰ See especially Snyder (1991), Kindle location 1282; Christensen (1996), p. 14; and Kupchan (1996), Chapter 2.

⁵¹ Snyder locates them in parochial interests; Kupchan locates them in cognitive biases associated with perceptions of vulnerability; and Christensen locates them in realist calculations about the national interest.

⁵² Snyder (1991), Kindle location 931–946; Kupchan (1996), pp. 87–92.

⁵³ Christensen (1996), pp. 16–17.

account I develop in the next chapter. But the conditions under which the entrapment mechanism – as it is deployed in these prominent accounts of over expansion – operates to push states toward sub-optimally aggressive policies require greater theoretical attention.

The root of the problem is that Snyder, Christensen, and Kupchan all model foreign policy legitimization as a fundamentally top-down process. Elites, who are either already in charge of foreign policy or who gain control through processes that are independent of legitimization games, develop a policy program and then work to gain support for it by bamboozling the public. They eventually succeed, and are then constrained in the future by their own success.

This model stands in contrast to another depiction of legitimization: as a contest between groups of elites who have opposing policy programs and draw on competing sets of rhetorical and political resources to gain the upper hand. Victory in these contests does not automatically go to the side advocating the more aggressive policy, but is rather influenced by variables like the elites' institutional positions, the character of preexisting discursive frameworks, and the kinds of arguments each side is able to draw upon.⁵⁴ Another way to put this is that aggressive myths, images, and mobilizing rhetoric do not always resonate with publics, and do not always trump the rhetorical and political efforts of elites pitching more moderate visions of the state's interests and grand strategy. Hitler's anti-status quo rhetoric did not launch him to prominence in Germany until the very end of the 1920s, even though he had been making similar arguments since the NSDAP was founded. Japanese militarists' loud campaign against status quo institutions did not overcome moderate objections to withdrawing from naval arms conventions and leaving the League of Nations until 1933.

What this suggests is that domestic explanations for over expansion based on the rhetorical and political appeal of expansionist myths or images need to be supplemented by an account of the conditions under which deeply aggressive policies are likely to be more easily sold than moderate policies. In the next chapter, I propose that widespread pessimism about the possibility of achieving status ambitions functions as one important rhetorical and political resource that produces advantages for advocates of provocatively aggressive policies over advocates of moderate policies.

⁵⁴ On this view of legitimization, see Krebs and Lobasz (2007), Krebs and Jackson (2007), Jackson (2006).